

Holy Cheese

Monks from an Italian monastic order introduce the taste of authentic mozzarella to Bangalore



SANJAY RAMCHANDRAN

FATHER MICHAEL
WITH HIS OFFERINGS

| By Stephen David |

Some monks live in caves. Others get by amidst the buzz of urban sprawl praying for world peace. Then there are those from the Benedictine monastery, a 1,000-year-old Roman Catholic order, who follow the motto *ora et labora*, prayer and work. An example is the monastery situated in Thambuchettipalya, near Bangalore, which produces the city's best Italian cheese. It is a concept formulated by Father Michael K.L., who joined the order about 20 years ago and learnt the nitty-gritty of cheese-making during his eight-year-long monastic training in Italy. His mentor, Father Rodolfo, advised the monk to consider making his two-acre 10-member monastery in Bangalore self-sustainable and that spurred him to cheese-making.

Rodolfo introduced him to an Italian businessman on work in India who checked with his friends and expats and realised that home-made Italian mozzarella was being missed most. With some samples made at a small centre in a corner of the monastery, Michael then shopped for buyers. "It was exceptional quality from the word go. We still buy from them," says Manjit Singh,

their first buyer and now owner of an Italian restaurant. Sold under the brand name Vallombrosa, expats from Italy and other Western nations were the other patrons. Until recently, an Italian restaurateur in Singapore was airlifting 100 kg of cheese every month until their government temporarily banned import of all dairy products.

The monks follow a military regimen. They get up at 5 a.m., pray from 5.45 to 8 a.m. and then work till 1.30 p.m. It is again back to prayers and theology classes till late evening. It is during work hours that a team of four, along with their drivers, will transform about 160 litres of buffalo milk into 40 kg of cheese. There is no advertising as, "the monks are not in the business for the sake of business," says Michael, whose Italian is as fluent as his mother tongue Malayalam. The money from the sales of cheese is not only used to run the monastery but also to pay for the school fee of 133 children. It would have been easier to tap the global Catholic body for funds but these monks, in keeping with their centuries-old motto, decide to say cheese with *ora et labora*.